

dedicated to their art.”

In 2017, when the introduction of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) on imported shooting equipment sparked concern, Jaspal emerged as one of its most vocal critics. He warned that steep taxation on pistols, rifles and other accessories would make the sport prohibitively expensive for young athletes and hurt India’s competitive pipeline.

For him, it was never about personal legacy. The fight was always about protecting the sport itself.

His methods were sometimes as polarising as they were effective. A bitter and very public fallout with Manu Bhaker ahead of the Tokyo Olympics threatened to overshadow one of Indian shooting’s most successful athlete-coach partnerships.

However, the duo eventually buried the hatchet, and Manu went on to make history by winning two medals at the next edition of the Summer Games.

On June 12, Indian sport lost one of its finest marksmen and mentors as the 2020 Dronacharya awardee breathed his last in a New Delhi hospital following heart-related complications.

He was 49. Which is perhaps why my last interaction with him, at a celebratory dinner in Mumbai on February 14, 2025, feels especially precious now.

This was right after he won the Sportstar Aces Coach of the Year award that evening for having guided Manu to the podium in Paris. As I sat by myself, wearily enjoying a tippie, I felt a hand on my shoulder. I looked up to see Jaspal, with a smile that reached the sharp eyes behind his glasses. “Today’s not a Saturday, but this is exactly how you should spend Saturdays. Lesson learned,” he quipped.

And that is how I will remember Jaspal. Not on a podium, not with a pistol in hand, nor as a voice of authority on the range, but with a reassuring hand on the shoulder, a disarming smile behind oversized spectacles, and one joke that took years to complete its journey.



Hero's welcome: Pistol ace Jaspal Rana is carried shoulder-high by supporters, alongside his wife Reema, upon his arrival at Indira Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi on September 23, 1998, after his triumphant campaign at the Commonwealth Games in Kuala Lumpur. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY



Golden reward: Jaspal Rana poses with the Gypsy presented to him by JCT in New Delhi after winning the individual gold medal at the Hiroshima Asian Games.

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